

### The Haitian revolt

In 1791, Haiti's enslaved rose in revolt. After a confused and bloody struggle, Haiti emerged in 1804 as the world's first black republic. It remains the only successful slave revolt in history. At first sight, a popular revolt may not seem obviously connected to a world of magic. However, Voudon was at the heart of the uprising, the catalyst that launched and sustained it. The mystical, other-worldly elements of Voudon were critical in the forging of a new nation. Whatever the many

sufferings Haiti has since endured, the longing for the divine, still at the core of Voudon, proved astonishingly effective in defying the combined might of France, Britain, Spain, and the US, countries that were all anxious to preserve slavery.

### New Orleans Voodoo

In the aftermath of the Haitian revolt, substantial numbers of formerly enslaved people and their descendants emigrated. Many settled in New Orleans, part of the US since 1803. Here, a

#### ► Voudon altar

All sorts of symbols are pressed into service to represent the teeming spirit world of Voudon. Dolls—the more brightly colored the better—have long been favored. Here, the snakes entwined around the arms of Mama Wati (a water spirit) are symbols of fertility and renewal.

